



It isn't as descriptive as it seeing it live, but the smoke from the incense sticks is fairly indicative as to how air flows in the top section of the cabinet. What you can't see here is the smoke being blown out the sides of the processor heatsink and then sucked and expunged by the power supply

Note: You should know that we did leave black charred marks in our white cabinet, and at least one person burnt his fingers, so be careful.

The PC

We used a regular-looking cabinet, and tried to recreate an average PC configuration to generate the type of heat that most of you should have within your cabinet.

The configuration was:

- AMD Athlon 64 3200+
- 2 x 512 MB Transcend DDR 400 RAM (without heatsinks)
- 80 GB Seagate hard drive (SATA)
- 120 GB Maxtor hard drive (SATA)
- MSI RS 480 motherboard
- ATI Radeon X1300 graphics card
- 380 W PowerSafe SMPS
- 1 stock rear cabinet fan
- Plector DVD-Writer (for the IDE cable)

This configuration generated 34 degrees Celsius of ambient cabinet temperature, which we measured using a temperature sensor that we got from a Zebtronics cabinet we had. This temperature was measured at the Windows desktop, after leaving the PC on, idling, for about half an hour.

In order to be able to show you the smoke / airflow, we also went out and bought a clear acrylic sheet for Rs 80. You can do this yourself as well, to keep the innards of your cabinet visible at all times.

Getting Ready

First things first—we decided to get rid of all the dust in the cabinet. Using our little orange hand blower, we realized that keeping the insides of the cabinet clean was quite a task. We took apart the whole system, and coughed and sneezed our way through blowing away all the dust. Even in our temperature-controlled office with sealed windows, we found quite a lot of it, so if you haven't opened your cabinet for over a year, wear a surgeon's mask!

The only thing we didn't open in search for dust was the SMPS, which was still within the warranty period. You should also avoid breaking any seals that can void your warranty. If all warranties have expired, don't be afraid to open out the SMPS cover as well (after disconnecting it from the mains, obviously) to get at that cake of dust that forms within all power supplies.

Now that we had a nice, gleaming PC, we went a little off track and Arctic Silver-ed the CPU, after

Tip

Round IDE Cable

A round IDE cable will help you push it to one side, and not obstruct airflow the way the flat cables do. If you have mainly IDE drives, make sure you get yourself a few round IDE cables to help air flow inside your cabinet. Unless they came bundled with your motherboard, the costs can be a little daunting, at around Rs 400. You could, however, gingerly pry out individual wires, or even pairs, from your flat IDE cable and bunch the lot together to make your own round IDE cable, as we have done here. Note that we take no responsibility if you botch up.

